

SYEDA JAHIRIN AKTARI

School of Analytics, Finance, and Economics, Southern Illinois University Carbondale

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EDUCATION

Southern Illinois University Carbondale <i>Ph.D. in Economics (2022 – 2027, Expected)</i> <i>Advisor: Professor Alison Watts</i>	<i>Carbondale, Illinois</i>
BRAC University <i>M.S. in Applied Economics, Cum Laude (2020 – 2022)</i>	<i>Dhaka, Bangladesh</i>
BRAC University <i>B.S.S in Economics, Summa Cum Laude (2016 – 2019)</i>	<i>Dhaka, Bangladesh</i>

FIELD OF INTERESTS

Teaching: Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, Econometrics, Development Economics, Game Theory, Industrial Organization, Monetary Economics, Health Economics, Environmental Economics

Research: Microeconomics, Industrial Organization, Education Economics, Causal Inference

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record <i>Department of Economics, Southern Illinois University Carbondale</i>	<i>(Spring 2025 – Summer 2025)</i>
ECON 334: Health Economics - Taught the demand and supply of health and medical services, healthcare market structure, the role of government in the healthcare industry, and models of regional coordination of hospital facilities. - Guided students in applying course concepts to current policy debates and real-world health outcomes.	<i>(Summer 2025)</i>
ECON 113: Economics of Contemporary Social Issues - Taught core economic concepts and evaluated policies designed to address a range of social problems. - Led discussions and provided step-by-step guidance on analytical and graphical economic problem-solving.	<i>(Spring 2025)</i>
Graduate Teaching Assistant <i>Department of Economics, Southern Illinois University Carbondale</i> Courses Assisted: ECON 240: Introduction to Microeconomics	<i>(Fall 2022 – Spring 2023)</i>
Graduate Teaching Assistant <i>Online Undergraduate Program, College of Business, Southern Illinois University Carbondale</i> Courses Assisted: MGMT 208: Business Data Analysis; MGMT 304: Introduction to Management; MGMT 446: Leadership and Managerial Behavior	<i>(Summer 2026 – Present)</i>
Graduate Teaching Assistant <i>Department of Economics, BRAC University</i> Courses Assisted: ECO 310: History of Economic Thought; ECO 306: Urban Economics; ECO 313: Environmental Economics	<i>(Spring 2020 – Spring 2021)</i>

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Higher Education and Its Effect on Political Participation: Evidence from Egypt”

This study investigates the impact of increasing access to higher education in Egypt through the abolition of university fees and the large-scale construction of public universities during the 1960s on long-term political participation, as a natural experiment. Using repeated cross-sectional data from the World Values Survey, we analyze the impact by exploiting variation in birth cohorts’ exposure to reforms. We use five measures of political engagement, including political interest, electoral participation (voting), and non-electoral political activities (signing petitions, joining boycotts and lawful demonstrations). We found that this increasing access to university education significantly increased university attainment. However, the result shows heterogeneous effects across different political participation. Compared to men, women benefited less from this university expansion in terms of university education attainment; however, we observe a stronger influence on women’s political participation than on men.

WORKING PAPERS

“Privacy Preservation and Efficiency in a Buyer-Seller Network: The Case of Spectrum Sharing” (NSF-funded, Grant #2332010)

“Does Higher Education Influence Gender Role Attitudes? Evidence From Egypt”

WORK IN PROGRESS

“The Composition of State Taxation and Business Dynamism: Evidence from U.S. Firm Entry and Job Flows, 1978–2022” (with Yaren Gocer and Mahesh M. Dhole)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Southern Illinois University Carbondale

(Fall 2023 – Fall 2024)

Graduate Research Assistant, NSF-Funded Project

- Contributed to an NSF-funded project on privacy protection in spectrum-sharing markets, examining trade-offs between data privacy, efficiency, and market pricing mechanisms.
- Developed an economic model demonstrating how privacy zones influence the buyer-seller network and affect equilibrium pricing.
- Analyzed how privacy mechanisms increase buyer payoffs and shape primary-user pricing strategies, leading to competitive versus monopoly pricing outcomes.
- Used game theory to model strategic interactions between primary and secondary users in the spectrum-sharing market.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

BRAC, Migration Programme

(March 2021 – July 2022)

Deputy Manager

- Secured, with the program team, \$2.5 million in funding for Sustainable Reintegration and Improved Migration Governance in collaboration with the EU and IRARA.
- Led the economic reintegration of 208 returnees, providing business planning support, financial resources, and ongoing monitoring.

CONFERENCE AND PRESENTATIONS

Midwest Economics Association Annual Meetings, Chicago, IL (2026)

Southern Economic Association, 95th Annual Meeting, Tampa, FL (2025)

Brown Bag Seminar, Southern Illinois University Carbondale (2025)

Southern Economic Association, 94th Annual Meeting, Washington, DC (2024)

Brown Bag Seminar, Southern Illinois University Carbondale (2024)

AWARDS AND HONORS

Dissertation Research Assistantship Award, SIU Carbondale (2025–2026)

Cum Laude, M.S. in Applied Economics, BRAC University (2022)

Summa Cum Laude, B.S.S in Economics, BRAC University (2019)

Full Tuition Scholarship, BRAC University (2016–2019)

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

Student Mentor, BRAC University (2018–2019)

Research Contributor, Bangladesh Chars Tobacco Assessment Project (2018)

Research Support and Data Analysis, Urban Economy of a Metropolis of Bangladesh (2020)

TECHNICAL SKILLS

STATA, R, EViews, MATLAB, Advanced MS Excel

REFERENCES

Alison Watts (Advisor)

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